Heart of Darkness. *Three Men in a Boat*. *Siddhartha*—some of the most moving and memorable stories I've had the pleasure of reading are all about rivers, the courses they run, the places they go to and the travellers they take along. These journeys are often revelatory, sometimes shocking but always awe-inspiring.

Earlier this year, on one monsoon evening, I ambled along a muddy path splitting bright jute fields in a village, unaware of its beleaguered past. A few hundred metres away stood the memorial to the most unforgettable skirmish in Indian history, now subject to wiry 20-somethings toting chunky cameras. It was here in the year 1757 that Nawab Siraj-ud-Daulah, betrayed by his commander Mir Jafar, lost to the East India Company's forces in a round of fighting that, as tour guides often like to add, lasted less than 40 minutes. This watershed event that played out at the banks of the Bhagirathi in Palashi—Plassey in history books—brought about the eventual installation of British rule in India.

The fact that the shift of the river has caused the actual battlefield to partially wash away notwithstanding, Palashi, named after the flame tree that grows here, looked blissfully underwhelming, a scruffy recluse that has long cast off the weight of history. I happened to witness it on the 'Historic Hooghly', a journey along the Ganga in West Bengal, aboard the *ABN Rajmahal*, operated by the pioneering river cruising company Assam Bengal Navigation.

A GANDER AT INDIA'S FIRST CANTONMENT TOWN

Having landed in Kolkata the night before and experienced

